11

New Rule at Samarkand

In the last week of July in AD 1500, Shaybāni Khān reached Samarkand after trusting the promises made by Zuhra Begi. He dismounted in the garden of the plain at noon. Sulṭān Ali Mīrzā went out to him through the four-roads gate without intimating any of his begs or trusted aides. Just keeping his mother's promise, he cared not to take the counsel of anyone and went ahead accompanied only by the most trusted people. What is very interesting is that even though the conspiracy was perhaps planned by Khwaja Yahya, Mīrzā did not share with him the fact that he was with Shaybāni.

Although Mīrzā expected the things to happen as schemed by his mother, Shaybāni Khān did not come out to receive him and further when he reached inside, he was made to sit on a seat symbolizing a person of lower stature compared to the owner.

Khwaja Yahya came to know about Sulṭān Ali Mīrzā's gullible adventure. Anxious and helpless, he rode out to Khān. The Khān looked at him in anger on his arrival and showering heated words asked him to take a leave. Helpless yet again, Yahya departed.

The news of Shaybāni Khān's arrival and Ali Mīrzā's meeting him had reached various corners. Now, Khwaja Ali Bay's son, Jan Ali came to know about it, and with the expectation to gain larger favour from Khān, he too went ahead to see him.

Babur has mentioned that it was indeed a dreadful act of Zuhra Begi who, in her folly, gave her son's house and other possessions to the winds to get herself a husband, Shaybāni Khān. But the latter didn't care even a bit for her. For him, she was neither equivalent of a mistress nor a concubine.

Ali Mīrzā was confounded by his act, and his penitence was extreme. Some from his close circle suggested he escape without creating much fuss.